

FORCE MULTIPLIER: China's new rail link in Tibet close to the border



CHINA HAS BEEN RAMPING UP INFRASTRUCTURE ON ITS SIDE OF LAC FOR FASTER TROOP MOVEMENT.

(Uttarakhand) and eastern, (North-east). The area of disputed boundary runs to about 2,800 km in all the three sectors. The two countries have undertaken a number of military confidence-building measures (CBMs) and have held 11 rounds of boundary negotiations, but this has yielded limited results. The next round is scheduled for January 2008.

While the two sides have the 1993 agreement to maintain peace and tranquillity on LAC and have agreed not to engage with each other's patrols and overlooked the minor ingressions because of the non-demarcation of the border, the pattern of these intrusions narrates a different story altogether. What is worrying is that the incursions have expanded to newer areas. On August 25 this year there was an intrusion in east Sikkim—China accepted Sikkim as part of India as a trade-off for recognition of its claim over Tibet. Even official maps of China acknowledge it as a part of India. So does that mean

Beijing has been violating Indian sovereignty at will? The Indian Government does not seem to have any answers.

According to the reports sent to the South Block, the violations in Trig Height area in Ladakh have increased and the Chinese violated LAC by flying a helicopter across it for the first time. Even in the Pangong Tso lake area in the western sector of the border in Ladakh violations are being carried out by boats in conjunction with vehicular patrols, the report says. South Block's assessment is that the Chinese want to draw the border in a straight line on the lake in the Western sector, which will prove to be strategically advantageous for them. Not far away in the same sector they have violated LAC from Demchok area in Ladakh from Charding nallah side for the first time this year.

According to South Block's assessment, Chinese intrusions in Demchok area have a strategic significance. "It can bring infantry and armoured

columns through Charding La, Jara La and Tashigong," the report says. There are other reports that Chinese forces now also dominate an Advance Landing Ground at Fukche near the Jammu and Kashmir border, where even aircraft and helicopters to land and provide logistics and military supplies to its forces. What has led to many an eyebrow being raised is the intelligence assessment that the Chinese build-up "can cut off supply line for Leh on Manali-Leh route without encountering Indian defences".

At Uttarakhand border with China, for the first time, the Chinese have transgressed into Barahoti area, the tents of Indian graziers have been uprooted and the Indian patrols have been missing from the area, says the report. The Chinese have crossed deep into the Indian territory up to Hotigad near Joshimath without facing any resistance. Barahoti has a strategic significance as this was the sector where Chinese incursions had taken place within three months of India and China signing the Panchsheel—the five principles of non-interference in 1954.

China's incursions extend far be-